What Stripe just made table stakes — and what it did not

A capability-by-capability comparison of our FY2027 trajectory against Stripe's published strategy. Which half of our differentiation survived, which recommendations from the review we adopt, which we decline, and the one finding that changes the sequence of the plan.

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PART

I — Reading the evidence

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How to read this document

> Half of what follows is analysis of a competitor. The other half is analysis of us. Only the second half is verifiable from inside this building, and the document is written so that you can tell which is which on every line.

Provenance

The Stripe material in this document comes from a competitive review supplied on 26 September 2026, synthesised from Stripe Sessions 2025 and 2026 transcripts, keynotes, newsroom announcements and product pages. It is detailed, internally coherent and almost certainly broadly right. It is also, for the most part, not something we have independently confirmed, and several of the specific launches it describes fall after the point at which our own reference material stops being reliable.

TAG	MEANING	HOW IT MAY BE USED
[S] Supplied	A claim about Stripe taken from the supplied review. Not independently verified.	Internal planning and prioritisation. **Not** customer-facing material, analyst briefings or competitive collateral without verification first.
[C] Calculated	A number derived here, from stated assumptions, with the method shown.	Anywhere, provided the assumptions travel with it.
[A] Actual	Something about our own estate, plan or architecture that we can check.	Anywhere.
[J] Judgement	An assessment with no number behind it. Argued, not measured.	As an argument, labelled as one. It is where reasonable people will disagree, and should.

THE VERIFICATION LIST

Before any of this reaches a customer, an analyst or a board paper, seven claims need first-party confirmation. They are the load-bearing ones:

- That Stripe Orchestration supports third-party processors in general availability, and on what commercial terms
- That Radar, Billing, Checkout and 3DS are genuinely usable on non-Stripe-processed transactions, and with what limits
- The scope and availability of the Forwarding API, and whether it covers stored credentials or only single-use data
- What the Payments Foundation Model is actually deployed against in production, as distinct from announced
- The basis of the quoted authorisation and checkout uplift figures — population, baseline and whether the comparison is a holdout
- Which Treasury and stablecoin capabilities are available in which jurisdictions, to which entity types
- Which agentic commerce components ship, and which are protocol proposals

The distinction between announced and generally available matters more than usual here. A competitor's roadmap compared against our shipped estate flatters them; a competitor's shipped estate compared against our roadmap flatters us. Both comparisons are being made in this document, and both are wrong in opposite directions.

What this document is for

It is not a competitor profile. It exists to answer three questions that PV-2027 can no longer answer on its own:

1. **Which parts of our stated differentiation are still differentiation**, now that a well-resourced competitor appears to have shipped two of the five pillars.
2. **Which of the eighteen recommendations in the review we act on**, which we modify and which we decline — each with a reason that survives being read back to us in a year.
3. **What changes in the sequence**, as distinct from what changes in the ambition. Most of the review's recommendations are about ambition. The important ones turned out to be about sequence.

The verdict, on one page

> The strategy is right and the positioning is now half wrong. Those are separable problems, and only one of them is urgent.

FINDING	WHERE IT LEAVES US
Two of our five pillars are no longer claims we can lead with. Multi-acquiring and Forward APIs both appear to be shipped by Stripe. [S]	They remain the two hardest things on our plan and the mechanism by which everything else becomes possible. They stop being the sentence at the top of the deck.
The thesis underneath them was validated, not invalidated. A competitor with every incentive to keep merchants captive chose to open its core instead.	That is the strongest external evidence our direction will ever get. It cost us nothing and it should change how confidently we fund the work.
The data gap is real and larger than the review states. Their advantage is depth on processed volume; ours can only ever be breadth across acquirers. [J]	Breadth is a genuinely different asset and worth building. It is not available by collecting data. It has to be manufactured through deliberate exploration, and that changes who owns it and when it arrives.
Our funding advantage and our slowness are the same fact. The balance sheet that makes accelerated funds defensible is the reason stablecoins and merchant-of-record are hard for us.	We should stop treating the second as a failure of ambition. We can claim the advantage or complain about the constraint, but not both.
The review's sequence is inverted on its two most consequential items. It puts a foundation model in FY2028 and agent identity in FY2030.	Agent identity is cheap now and a breaking change later. A foundation model is expensive now and cheaper later, because it waits on data we have not collected. Swap them.
Proof survives the comparison better than anything else we have. Not because competitors cannot measure, but because almost nobody publishes an interval that can embarrass them.	This is the one claim that a conflicted orchestrator can make and an unconflicted one cannot beat. It is also a commercial and legal decision before it is a product decision.

THE ONE-SENTENCE VERSION

Stripe validated our architecture and commoditised our slogan; the response is to keep building exactly what we are building, stop describing it as the differentiator, and move the claim up one level — to the intelligence and economics that multi-acquiring exists to make possible.

That is close to what the review concludes. Where we differ is on timing, on three of the four horizons, and on whether the FY2027 positioning should be retired before FY2027 has happened.

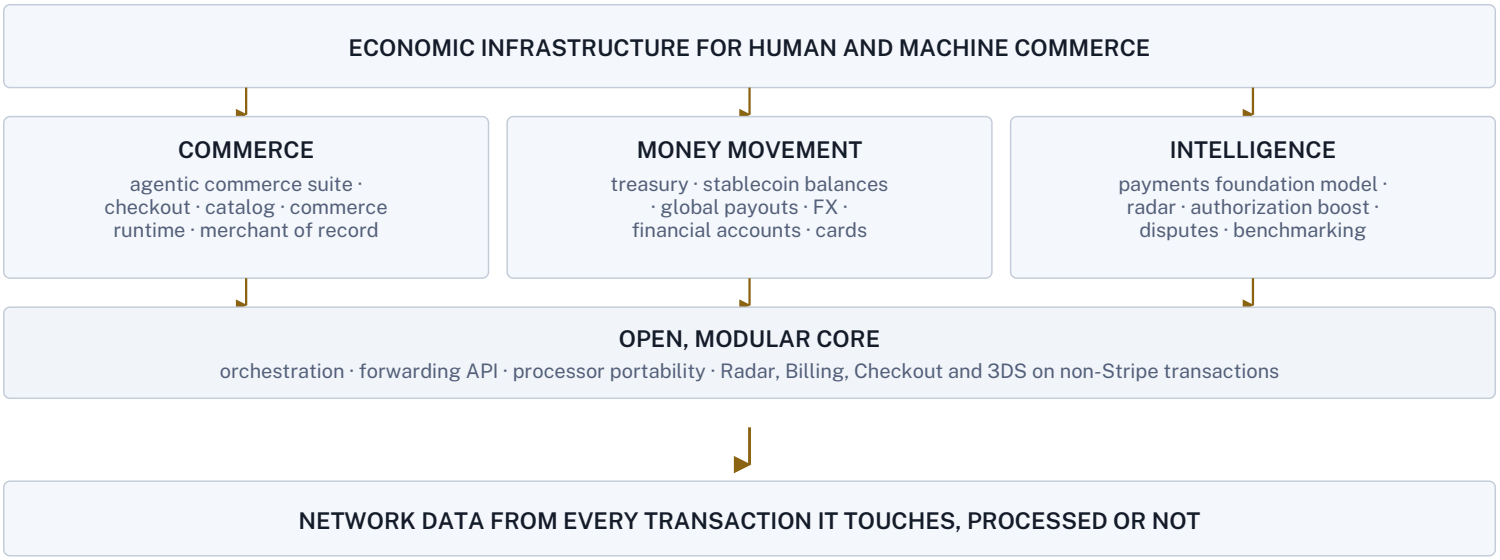
The scoring

DISPOSITION	COUNT	WHAT IT COVERS
Adopt as recommended	6	Portable infrastructure as a principle; economic objective function; payment intelligence as a service; the four horizons; the instrument graph expansion; agentic model extension.
Adopt with a stated condition	3	Payment intelligence layering; the north-star metric; rail-neutral payout architecture.
Adapt	5	Multi-acquiring repositioning; money movement framing; foundation model; local payment methods; network-scale fraud.
Decline, with reasons	4	Retiring the FY2027 positioning now; replacing five pillars with four layers; merchant-of-record; commerce runtime.
Already in the plan — the review missed it	2	Platform and embedded finance strategy; migration as a competitive asset rather than a cost.

What Stripe is doing, as the research describes it

> Everything in this section is tagged [S]. It is a faithful rendering of the supplied review rather than an independent assessment, and it is the input to the rest of the document.

STRIPE'S DIRECTION AS DESCRIBED IN THE SUPPLIED RESEARCH · [S] UNVERIFIED



— The bottom row is the point. Every layer above it exists partly to widen the bottom row. Opening the core is not generosity; it is data acquisition, which is the same reason our own multi-acquiring thesis is correct.

MOVE	WHAT IS CLAIMED [S]	WHY IT MATTERS TO US
Open the core	Orchestration across third-party processors, a Forwarding API, processor portability, and Radar, Billing, Checkout and 3DS usable on transactions Stripe does not process.	Direct overlap with pillars one and two. This is the move that changes our positioning.
A payments foundation model	A single model trained on tens of billions of transactions, applied across fraud, authorisation and disputes, replacing a set of task-specific models.	The largest genuine capability gap. Not because we cannot build models, but because we have not yet collected what trains them.
Optimization as a priced product	Authorization Boost bundling adaptive acceptance, account updater, network tokens, issuer-optimised messaging and retries, marketed with an average uplift figure.	Confirms that optimization is monetisable as a product rather than absorbed into rate. It also sets an expectation that we will be asked to match a published number.
Treasury as a feature	Multi-currency balances, instant transfers, global payouts, financial accounts, cards, and stablecoin balances following the Bridge acquisition.	Attacks the pillar we thought was structurally ours. It does not neutralise it — see the section on cost of funds — but it removes the assumption that nobody else is trying.
Agents as economic actors	An agentic commerce suite, agent wallets and authentication, and machine payment protocols for agent-initiated and agent-to-agent transactions.	The only item on this list that changes our data model rather than our roadmap. That makes it cheap now and expensive later.
Payments data as enterprise intelligence	Benchmarking, risk, pricing and revenue intelligence built from network data and sold beyond the payments team.	The most directly copyable idea on the list, and the cheapest for us, because it is largely a presentation of data our FY2027 build already produces.

THE PATTERN UNDERNEATH THE SIX

Read together, the moves are not six bets. They are one bet made six ways: that the durable position is above the transaction rather than inside it, and that the way to get there is to widen the set of transactions you can observe — including the ones you do not process.

We reached the same conclusion independently and wrote it down in PV-2027 as "compete for the layer that decides, not for all the volume". The uncomfortable part is not that they are doing something different. It is that they are doing the same thing, earlier, with a decade of compounding behind them.

The commoditisation test

> Before deciding what to change, it is worth having a rule for what counts as differentiation at all. Most competitive reviews fail because they never state one.

A capability differentiates only if it passes at least one of three gates. Everything else is table stakes — which is not the same as worthless, and the distinction matters more than the label.

GATE	THE QUESTION	WHAT PASSING LOOKS LIKE
Gate 1 — capability	Can a well-resourced competitor ship this if they decide to?	Almost nothing passes gate 1 in payments. Software is not the scarce input.
Gate 2 — cost base	Can they ship it at a cost that lets them price against us?	Structural. Balance sheet, regulatory licence, existing relationships, cost of funds. Passing here is durable because it is not a build decision.
Gate 3 — proof	Can they ship it ***and*** defend the number it produces?	Requires infrastructure most organisations decline to build, because it produces numbers that can disappoint. Passing here is durable for organisational reasons rather than technical ones.

THE TEST · A CAPABILITY DIFFERENTIATES ONLY IF IT PASSES AT LEAST ONE GATE

	GATE 1 They cannot ship it	GATE 2 They cannot ship it at our cost base	GATE 3 They can ship it but cannot prove it
Multi-acquiring	× no	× no	× no
Forward APIs	× no	× no	× no
Accelerated funds	× no	✓ yes	× no
Instrument intelligence	× no	× no	~ conditional
Payment optimization	× no	× no	✓ yes

TWO PILLARS PASS NO GATE · ONE PASSES ON COST · TWO PASS ONLY CONDITIONALLY

That is the honest score. It is also a reason to build, not a reason to stop — no gate is passed by a roadmap.

— The two pillars that fail every gate are still the two hardest things on our plan, and they remain the mechanism by which the conditional gates become unconditional. They stop being the sentence we lead with; they do not stop being the work.

Reading the score honestly

PILLAR	SCORE	THE HONEST READING
Multi-acquiring	Fails all three	As a claim, this is over. Stripe ships it, the independent orchestrators have shipped it for years, and the buyer already knows. What remains is execution quality and the fact that this is how we acquire the data that feeds gates 2 and 3 elsewhere.
Forward APIs	Fails all three	Same position, and slightly worse: our version is an API and theirs appears to be too, so the comparison is feature-level and we are behind on developer surface. The fix is not a better API. It is to stop treating one API as a pillar.
Accelerated funds	Passes gate 2	The only clean pass on the page. A non-bank reaches instant settlement through a partner bank or a capital arrangement; both add cost and a counterparty. This is a real, durable, structural advantage and PV-2027 under-sells it.
Instrument intelligence	Conditional on gate 3	Three of its four layers — what the instrument is, what it can do, what it costs — are purchasable. The fourth, how it behaves, is not purchasable, and is also not collectable. See the section on the exploration budget: this gate is passed by an experiment programme, not by a data warehouse.
Payment optimization	Passes gate 3 only	Everyone optimises. The difference is whether the uplift can be stated with an interval against a holdout that the commercial team cannot switch off. That is an organisational commitment more than a technical one, which is exactly why it is defensible.

WHAT THE SCORE DOES NOT MEAN

It does not mean we should stop building the two pillars that fail every gate. It means we should stop ***selling*** them as the reason to choose us, while continuing to fund them as the reason everything else becomes possible.

The review makes this point and then partly loses it, by recommending we restructure the strategy around the things that survive the test. That is the wrong conclusion. A capability can be table stakes and still be the critical path — and in this case the two that fail the test are precisely what produce the volume and the evidence that let the conditional gates close.

What their moves validate

> The review spends thirty sections on what Stripe has taken from us and one paragraph on what they have confirmed. The ratio should be closer to even.

A competitor opening its own core is an expensive, reversible-only-with-difficulty decision made against its short-term interest. When an organisation with better data than ours, and every incentive to keep merchants locked in, chooses instead to support the processors it competes with, that is the strongest form of external validation available: a rival spending its own money to prove our thesis.

OUR CLAIM IN PV-2027	WHAT THEIR MOVE IMPLIES [S]	CONFIDENCE AFTER
Enterprises will not accept single-acquirer concentration, and the orchestration layer is being bought explicitly	A processor with the largest direct book chose to support competing processors rather than defend exclusivity	Materially higher. This was our biggest assumption and it now has a second party betting on it.
The durable relationship moves from the processing layer to the decision layer	Their entire open-core architecture is an attempt to hold the decision layer while conceding processing	Confirmed. We are not alone in the reading, which also means we are not early.
Optimization is a product with a price, not a feature absorbed into rate	Authorization Boost is priced and marketed with a headline number	Confirmed, and with a commercial template we can study rather than invent.
Services should be usable independently of who processes	Radar, Billing, Checkout and 3DS offered on non-Stripe transactions	Confirmed, and it raises the bar: our shared services must be genuinely processor-independent, not independent in principle and coupled in practice.
Payment data has value beyond the payments team	Benchmarking and revenue intelligence sold to the wider business	Confirmed. This was a hypothesis in PV-2027 and is now an observed market.

THE DANGEROUS WAY TO READ THIS

“Stripe validated us” is a comfortable sentence and it has been the last sentence of many strategies that then lost. Validation of a direction says nothing about our ability to execute it against a competitor who reached it first and iterates faster.

The correct reading is narrower and more useful: **the market risk in our strategy has fallen and the execution risk has risen.** Those call for different responses. Lower market risk justifies funding the pillars harder. Higher execution risk means we should be ruthless about which races we enter, which is what the selection rule later in this document is for.

06

The competitor the comparison leaves out

> The supplied review frames orchestration as us against Stripe. In the deals we actually lose, there is usually a third party in the room, and its pitch is that both of us are compromised.

ORCHESTRATION IS A THREE-WAY CONTEST, NOT A DUEL

US	STRIPE	INDEPENDENTS
POSITION Acquirer that orchestrates	POSITION Processor that orchestrates	POSITION Orchestration only
CONFLICT Conflicted: we compete with the acquirers we route to	CONFLICT Conflicted: the same problem, larger book	CONFLICT Unconflicted, and they say so in every deal
ADVANTAGE Estate presence · bank funding · regulated trust	ADVANTAGE Developer surface · data depth · shipping speed	ADVANTAGE Neutrality · no acquiring book to protect

NEITHER WE NOR STRIPE CAN CLAIM NEUTRALITY. WE CAN ONLY CLAIM MEASURED NEUTRALITY.

A holdout that shows our own acquiring losing, published to the merchant, is the only version of the claim that survives procurement.

— The supplied research frames this as us against Stripe. In an enterprise RFP the independent orchestrator is usually also in the room, and its entire pitch is that both of us are conflicted. Proof is how a conflicted party answers that, and it is the one answer an independent cannot beat on price.

Independent orchestrators have no acquiring book. That is their whole proposition and it is not a weak one: when a merchant asks who decides where the transaction goes, “a party who earns more if it goes one way” is an uncomfortable answer. We have that problem. So does Stripe, more acutely, because their book is larger.

What each of the three can and cannot say

CLAIM	US	STRIPE [S]	INDEPENDENT
“We have no interest in where your volume goes”	No	No	Yes
“We can settle your funds in hours because we are the bank”	Yes	No	No
“We see this instrument on several acquirers”	Yes, at scale	Partly	Yes, but thinner
“We can show you a holdout that includes our own acquiring losing”	Yes, if we choose to	Possible	No book to lose with
“We already run inside your estate and your change-control process”	Often yes	Rarely	No
“We can carry the regulatory and audit burden of your payment estate”	Yes	Partly	No

THE ONLY ANSWER TO THE NEUTRALITY QUESTION

A conflicted orchestrator cannot win the neutrality argument by asserting neutrality. It can only win by making its conflict observable and its decisions auditable — which means publishing the comparison that includes our own acquiring, on the merchant’s own traffic, whether or not we come out ahead.

That is precisely the holdout and evidence infrastructure PV-2027 already commits to, which is worth noticing: **the evidence platform is not only a product feature, it is the answer to the single strongest objection a competitor makes about us.** It should be priced and positioned accordingly, and it is the reason the proof pillar matters more after this review than before it.

There is also a segment consequence. Against an independent, our funding and estate advantages are decisive and their neutrality is the only counter. Against Stripe, neutrality is a wash and the contest is data depth against funding structure. The two competitors therefore require different pitches, and PV-2027’s buyer-segment section should carry that split. [J]

PART

II — The comparison

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09 Where we are behind and it does not matter

10 The four things that remain structurally ours

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Capability by capability

> The review's comparison table has three columns: our vision, their 2026 position, and a strategic implication. It is missing the column that decides anything, which is whether the capability needs to be ours at all.

Four dispositions are possible for any capability, and only two of them generate work:

DISPOSITION	MEANING
Build	We need it, it differentiates or it gates something that does, and nobody else will build it for us.
Reach	We need it to be available to our merchants, and the cheapest route is through an acquirer, a partner or the portability principle rather than our own build.
Match	We need parity because its absence loses deals, but excellence buys nothing. Build to the point of sufficiency and stop.
Decline	We do not need it. Saying so explicitly is the only way a roadmap stays finite.

The table

Stripe's column is [S] throughout. Ours is [A] for anything already in EA-001, EA-002 or PV-2027, and [J] for the disposition.

CAPABILITY	OUR POSITION [A]	STRIPE [S]	DISPOSITION [J]
Multi-acquiring / orchestration	Core pillar, in build	Launched	**Build.** No longer a claim; still the critical path and the data-acquisition mechanism.
Forward / portability APIs	Core pillar, in build	Forwarding API launched	**Build**, but as one implementation of a wider principle, not as the pillar itself.
Processor-neutral shared services	Planned, boundaries defined in EA-001	Radar, Billing, Checkout, 3DS on non-Stripe volume	**Build.** They are ahead. Our advantage is that ours were designed processor-independent from the start rather than retrofitted.
Routing and decisioning	Decision platform, in build	Orchestration routing	**Build.** Parity contest on mechanics; the differentiation sits in the objective function, not the router.
Optimization	Holdout and proof discipline	AI-driven, priced, published uplift	**Build.** Keep the proof discipline; adopt the product packaging.
Instrument intelligence	Major pillar; graph specified	Implicit in the foundation model	**Build.** The behaviour layer is the only part that is ours to own.
Transaction and network intelligence	Emerging, partly implied	Foundation model	**Build.** Largest genuine gap. Gated on volume, not on ambition.
Model-based decisioning	Decision platform provides the slot	Foundation model plus lifecycle AI	**Build, later.** Gated on evidence volume and model-risk approval, not on modelling capability.
Fraud intelligence at network scale	Boundary exists; scale does not	Radar at network scale	**Match.** Pooled portfolio signal, same governance problem as instrument behaviour.
Accelerated funds	Structural advantage, under-sold	Treasury plus instant payouts	**Build.** The clean structural win. Deserves more of the roadmap than it has.
Treasury and balances	Limited in the vision	Major focus	**Build.** Adjacent to a capability we already have as an institution and barely expose as a product.
Stablecoins	Peripheral	Strategic, post-Bridge	**Reach.** Rail-neutral architecture now; the rail itself on an exercise condition.
Agentic commerce	Not central	Core strategy	**Build the model, decline the suite.** Contract objects now; wallets and agent-to-agent later or never.
Machine payments protocols	Not central	MPP, x402	**Reach.** Protocols converge or die; we should implement the survivor, not bet on one.
Platform and embedded finance	Already a section of PV-2027	Major growth engine	**Build.** The review missed that this is already in the plan; the gap is depth, not presence.
Billing and revenue	Supporting	Major business	**Reach.** Enterprise merchants mostly own billing in an ERP. Different buyer from Stripe's base.
Local payment method breadth	Supporting	Large published count	**Reach.** Parity on count is the wrong target; parity on the methods our four segments need is the right one, via acquirers.
Merchant of record	Not central	Managed Payments	**Decline.** A materially different regulatory posture for a bank. Revisit only with a legal-entity answer.
Commerce runtime	Not present	Emerging	**Decline.** Not our buyer and not our competence.
Data network effect	Implied	Explicit weapon	**Build.** Real gap, and the section on the exploration budget explains why it is not closed by collecting data.
Experimentation and counterfactuals	Strongest asset	Present within optimization	**Build.** The one place we may genuinely be ahead on discipline, if not on scale.
Migration of a large regulated estate	Six-stage model, specified	Less central publicly	**Build.** Undervalued by the review. See the note below.

Bank balance sheet and funding	Major	Increasingly financial, but not a bank	**Build.** The one gate-2 pass we have.
Developer surface and ecosystem	Behind	A decade ahead	**Match.** Enough not to lose on it. We will not win on it and should stop measuring ourselves by it.

ON MIGRATION, WHICH THE REVIEW MARKS AS A FOOTNOTE

The review lists migration as a “potential advantage” and moves on. It is more than that, and it cuts in a direction the review does not notice.

For Stripe to orchestrate a large enterprise estate, the merchant must place Stripe ***above*** its existing acquirers. In a regulated estate that is a change-control event of roughly the same magnitude as switching acquirer: new contracts, new certification, new PCI scope, new operational runbooks, new reconciliation. The switching cost that has always protected incumbents protects us here, because we are already inside the estate and already in the change-control process.

This is an advantage with a half-life. It holds while orchestration is a project and evaporates once it becomes a procurement line item. [J]

Where we are behind and it matters

> Three gaps are worth losing sleep over. Everything else on the list is either reachable, declinable, or a race we should not enter.

1. Transaction and network intelligence

This is the real gap and the review is right to lead with it. The distinction is not that they have models and we do not; it is that a model trained across a very large transaction population learns relationships that no amount of feature engineering recovers from a smaller one. Scale is doing the work, and scale is the input we lack.

What makes this tractable rather than hopeless is that our target is not their model. It is a different question — not “will this authorise” but “which acquirer authorises this best” — and that question is unanswerable from single-path data however large the population. The next section puts numbers on what it would take.

2. Treasury exposed as a product

We have treasury capability at institutional scale and almost none of it is exposed as a product a merchant can consume through a payments API. A competitor without a bank charter has built a more usable treasury surface than the bank has. That is an uncomfortable sentence and it is accurate. [J]

The gap is not capability, it is packaging — which in PV-2027 terms is the seven obligations applied to something the organisation currently treats as internal plumbing. That makes it one of the cheaper gaps to close and one of the higher-value ones, because it sits on top of our only clean gate-2 pass.

3. Time to learn

The structural gap nobody puts in a comparison table. A competitor with a self-serve base ships a change and reads the result in days. We ship to an enterprise base through change control and read the result in quarters. The ratio is something like five to ten to one, and it is not fixable by working harder. [J]

The consequence is a rule rather than a project, and it is the most useful thing in this document: **any strategy whose advantage depends on out-iterating this competitor will lose.** Strategies whose advantage accumulates with time in market — funding relationships, installed estate, evidence history, instrument behaviour — win, because those compound whether or not we shipped anything this month. That rule is developed in Part IV and it settles most of the open arguments.

Where we are behind and it does not matter

> The discipline of a competitive review is not in what it commits to. It is in what it refuses, in writing, so that somebody cannot quietly add it back next quarter.

GAP	WHY IT LOOKS URGENT	WHY IT IS NOT
Developer surface area	It is the most visible difference and the easiest to demo against us	Our buying committee is a head of payments, a treasurer and a CFO, evaluating over months with an integration partner. Documentation quality matters; it is not what the decision turns on. Build to sufficiency and stop measuring ourselves on it.
Payment method count	A published number we cannot match, and procurement asks for it	The number is a proxy for coverage of markets a merchant actually sells in. Our four segments need perhaps thirty methods, and portability means we can reach most of the rest through acquirers rather than building them. Answer the coverage question, not the count question.
Commerce runtime and storefront	It appears in their strategy diagram, so it looks like a category	It is a different business with a different buyer and no adjacency to anything we own. Entering it would be the clearest possible signal that the strategy has no edges.
Merchant of record	It is adjacent, it is monetisable, and a competitor is doing it	Taking on seller-of-record status changes tax, consumer-protection and regulatory posture for a bank in ways that require a legal-entity answer before a product answer. Declining now is not the same as declining forever; it is declining until somebody has done the entity work.
Agent wallets and agent-to-agent settlement	It is the most exciting item in the review	The exciting part is the protocol, and the protocols are unsettled. Implementing an unsettled protocol early buys a migration. The part that is genuinely urgent is the data model, which is cheap and covered separately.
Stablecoin issuance	A competitor acquired a company to do it	Issuance is a regulatory programme, not a product sprint, and for a bank it runs through a different set of approvals entirely. The part we should do now is architectural: leave the rail slot open.

THE COST OF NOT WRITING THIS DOWN

Every item above will be proposed again, by somebody credible, within two quarters, usually in response to a single lost deal or a single competitor announcement. A refusal that is not documented with its reason is not a refusal; it is a delay.

Each of these should be revisited on a stated trigger rather than on a schedule or a mood. The triggers are in Part IV.

The four things that remain structurally ours

> After the commoditisation test, four things survive. Three are structural and one is organisational, and the organisational one is the most defensible of the set.

1. Cost of funds

A non-bank reaching instant settlement does so through a partner bank or a pre-funded capital arrangement. Both work. Both add a counterparty, a margin and a constraint on how far the acceleration can be pushed before someone's risk appetite binds. Our version is a balance-sheet decision inside one institution. That is a gate-2 pass and it does not expire with a product release.

The honest qualifier: this advantage is currently theoretical in the sense that it is not packaged, priced or metered as a product. An advantage that cannot be bought is not yet an advantage. Closing that is the highest-return item in the whole comparison. [J]

2. Cross-acquirer instrument behaviour

They can know, better than anyone, how an instrument behaves on their own rails. Nobody can know from single-path data how the same instrument behaves on a *different* acquirer, because the observation does not exist. That asymmetry is genuine and it is the one data position where scale does not automatically decide the winner.

It is also the most over-claimed idea in the review, for reasons set out in the next section. The signal is not lying in our data waiting to be extracted. It has to be produced.

3. Presence inside a regulated estate

We are already in the change-control process, already in the audit scope, already in the reconciliation. For a large regulated merchant, that is the difference between a configuration change and a programme. It is why our migration model is a competitive asset rather than a cost line, and it is why the review's dismissal of it is the clearest thing it gets wrong.

4. Proof that can embarrass us

The one organisational moat. Any competent competitor can measure. Very few will commit to a permanent holdout, a published interval and a number that can come out negative on their own product, because doing so requires a commercial organisation to accept variance it currently does not have to accept.

WHAT PROOF ACTUALLY COSTS US

PV-2027 treats proof as a technical commitment. It is not. Making economic proof contractual — which is what turns it from a feature into a moat — means:

- Revenue that varies with measured performance, which is a treasury and forecasting decision
- A published number that can be negative, which is a legal and communications decision
- A holdout that the commercial team cannot switch off under pressure, which is a governance decision
- Comparisons that will sometimes show our own acquiring losing, which is a decision the acquiring business has to make and will not enjoy

Each of these is decidable. None of them is a product decision, and if they are treated as product decisions they will be quietly softened until the moat is a marketing line. This should be escalated as four explicit approvals, not assumed.

The data asymmetry, scored honestly

> This section contains the finding that changes the plan. It is also the section most likely to be argued with, so the arithmetic is shown rather than asserted.

The comfortable version of our data story is: they have depth on their own volume, we will have breadth across acquirers, breadth is rarer, therefore we win a different game. Every clause is true. The conclusion does not follow, because breadth of the useful kind is not a property of data we will passively accumulate.

WHY CROSS-ACQUIRER INTELLIGENCE IS A PORTFOLIO ASSET, NOT A MERCHANT ASSET

The signal we want	"This instrument performs better on acquirer B than on acquirer A"
What produces it	The same instrument class routed both ways, deliberately, at the same time
Why it does not occur naturally	Production routing is deterministic. It sends each instrument one way, forever.
So it must be manufactured	A standing exploration budget — a slice of traffic routed against the current best guess
Which makes it an experiment	Same infrastructure as the holdout: assignment, propensity, counterfactual, power

EXPLORATION IS CHEAP. VOLUME IS NOT.

A 2% exploration budget against a 50 bps acquirer gap costs about 0.5 bps of approvals — roughly $50k of authorised volume per $1bn. The binding constraint is orchestrated transactions per month, which is exactly what multi-acquiring buys.

— This is the finding that changes the roadmap. Cross-acquirer intelligence is not a data-collection project that runs in the background; it is an exploration programme with a power calculation, and it only reaches useful granularity when merchant traffic is pooled.

Why the signal does not occur naturally

To learn that an instrument class performs better on acquirer B than on acquirer A, we need the same class routed both ways in the same period, with everything else held roughly constant. Production routing does the opposite by design: it is deterministic, it sends each class to whichever acquirer the current rules prefer, and it keeps doing so. A year of that produces a large dataset containing no comparison at all.

So the comparison has to be manufactured — a standing exploration budget that deliberately routes a slice of traffic against the current best guess. Which means cross-acquirer intelligence is not a data programme. It is an experiment programme, running on exactly the assignment, propensity and counterfactual infrastructure PV-2027 is already building for the holdout. [J]

What it costs, and what it needs

Two numbers, both [C]. First the cost, which is the surprising one.

EXPLORATION IS CHEAP

Suppose a 2% exploration budget and a true difference of 50 bps in approval between two acquirers for the class being explored. Half the explored traffic lands on the worse arm, so the expected cost is 1% × 50 bps = **0.5 bps of approvals** — about $50,000 of authorised volume per $1bn routed, or on a 2% merchant net margin roughly $1,000 of merchant margin per $1bn.

The usual objection to exploration is that it costs approvals. At this scale the objection does not survive contact with the arithmetic. The scarce input is not risk tolerance. It is transactions.

Second, the volume. Detecting a difference of size d in a binary outcome at 80% power and 95% confidence, around an 88% baseline, needs roughly:

$$n \text{ per arm} = (z_{0.975} + z_{0.80})^2 \times [\, p_1(1-p_1) + p_2(1-p_2) \,] / d^2$$

```
d = 25 bps   →   262,800 per arm   (525,700 total)
d = 50 bps   →    65,100 per arm   (130,200 total)
d = 100 bps  →    16,000 per arm    (31,900 total)
d = 200 bps  →     3,800 per arm     (7,700 total)
```

Those are transactions ***within the segment being compared***, and they have to be explored transactions, not total ones. That is where the problem appears. A segment worth acting on is not “all traffic”; it is something like issuer group × channel × MCC × amount band, which is a small slice of any one merchant’s volume.

The granularity ladder

Holding the exploration budget at 2% and the reading period at six months, this is the orchestrated volume required to resolve one segment at a given granularity: [C]

SEGMENT GRANULARITY	SHARE OF VOLUME	TXNS / MONTH FOR A 50 BPS READ	FOR A 100 BPS READ
Channel × issuer group	~10%	10.9M	2.7M
… × MCC	~5%	21.7M	5.3M
… × amount band	~2%	54.3M	13.3M
… × token type	~1%	108.5M	26.6M
… × geography	~0.5%	217.0M	53.2M

THE CONSEQUENCE, WHICH IS NOT SMALL

A single merchant cannot fund this. At 500,000 transactions a month and a 2% exploration budget, reading even a whole-merchant 50 bps difference takes about 13 months; reading a 2%-of-volume segment takes decades. [C]

Cross-acquirer instrument intelligence is therefore a portfolio asset, not a merchant asset. It only exists if exploration is pooled across merchants and governed centrally. Four consequences follow immediately, and none of them are in PV-2027 today:

- **Consent and data rights.** Pooling means merchant A’s exploration informs merchant B’s routing. That has to be in the contract, in the entitlement model, and in a form a merchant’s legal team will sign.
- **Central ownership of the exploration budget.** If each merchant team sets its own, it will be negotiated to zero by the first merchant who asks why we are deliberately routing their traffic sub-optimally. The budget is a platform-level parameter, with the same immutability discipline as the holdout.
- **Start coarse.** At plausible FY2028 volumes we can resolve channel × issuer group, and possibly one level finer. Anything more granular should not be on a roadmap until the volume supports it. Promising instrument-level cross-acquirer intelligence in 2028 is promising something the arithmetic will not deliver.
- **Effect size is a product decision.** A 100 bps target is four times cheaper to resolve than a 50 bps one. We should decide, deliberately, that we are in the business of finding large differences quickly rather than small differences eventually.

This is also, incidentally, the strongest possible argument for the multi-acquiring pillar after it has stopped being a differentiator. Orchestrated volume is the input to the only data asset we can own. The review says this in a single line near its conclusion; it deserves to be the reason the pillar stays funded at all.

How large the prize actually is

> Before anyone commits to “optimising the economics of every payment”, it is worth knowing how much of those economics either party can reach.

THE CONTESTABLE SHARE OF THE COST STACK

Interchange ~62%

Set by the issuer and the scheme. Neither we nor Stripe move it, except through instrument and data choices.

Scheme and network fees ~14%

Rule-driven. Marginally contestable through message quality and token type.

Acquirer and processing margin ~15%

Contestable through routing, negotiation and competition between acquirers.

Fraud, retries, operations ~9%

Contestable through decisioning, recovery and authentication strategy.

ROUGHLY A QUARTER OF THE COST STACK IS CONTESTABLE BY ANY ORCHESTRATOR

Illustrative shares for a blended card-present and card-not-present mix. The point is the order of magnitude, not the digits.

— Worth saying out loud before anyone promises to “optimise the economics of every payment”. The approval side of the equation has no such ceiling, which is why expected value beats cost reduction as the objective — an approval recovered is revenue, not a rebate.

Interchange is set by the issuer and the scheme. Neither we nor any competitor moves it directly; it is influenced only indirectly, through instrument choice, data quality, authentication and rate qualification. Scheme fees are rule-driven and marginally contestable. What is left — acquirer margin, processing, fraud, retries and operations — is roughly a quarter of the stack, and that quarter is what every optimization claim in this market is actually competing over. [J]

WHICH IS WHY THE OBJECTIVE MATTERS MORE THAN THE OPTIMISER

Cost reduction has a hard ceiling set by the three-quarters of the stack nobody in this contest controls. Approval improvement does not: a recovered authorisation is merchant revenue, and merchant revenue is several multiples of the entire cost stack it sits on.

That is the real argument for the review’s best idea — an expected-value objective rather than an approval-rate or a cost objective. Not because it sounds more sophisticated, but because it is the only formulation in which the large term and the small terms are traded off in the same unit. A 20 bps approval gain and a 2 bps cost saving are not comparable until they are both in dollars.

It is also the honest answer to the executive question this document will provoke: no, we cannot optimise the economics of every payment. We can contest about a quarter of the cost, and we can move the revenue side, and the second is where the money is. Saying that plainly is better than being asked about it later.

PART

III — What we change

13 What we adopt as recommended

14 What we adopt with a stated condition

15 What we adapt

16 What we decline

17 The positioning question

18 Economic value per orchestrated dollar

What we adopt as recommended

> Six recommendations are correct as written, and four of the six are cheap. That is an unusually good hit rate for a competitive review and it is worth saying so.

1. Portability as an architectural principle, not a pillar

Forward API becomes one implementation of **portable payment infrastructure**: the commitment that a merchant can move execution without rebuilding their commerce stack. The principle covers credentials, payment methods, intents, orders, history, routing, risk signals, authorisation, refunds, disputes, settlement, reporting, configuration, entitlements and data.

This is a better claim than the API it replaces for three reasons. It is not matchable by shipping one endpoint. It is testable — for each of those fifteen surfaces we can state whether a merchant can actually leave with it, which most competitors cannot. And it converts a feature comparison into a commitment comparison, which is the comparison a conflicted orchestrator wants to be having.

THE TEST THAT MAKES IT REAL

A portability principle that is not measured becomes a slogan within one planning cycle. The measure is blunt and should go on the FY2027 scorecard: **for each of the fifteen surfaces, can a merchant extract it and operate elsewhere, without our assistance, within a stated time?** Yes, partially, or no. Published internally, quarterly, per surface.

Expect the first reading to be embarrassing. That is the point of a measure.

2. An economic objective function

The best idea in the review. Today a routing strategy optimises an approval rate or a cost. It should optimise expected economic value:

```
E[value]  =  P(approve) × merchant revenue
           - processing cost    - network cost
           - E[fraud loss]      - FX cost
           - retry cost         - operational cost
           - funding cost       +  LTV effect
```

The change is small in the decision platform — the objective is already a registered, versioned artefact — and large in consequence, because it is the only formulation in which a 20 bps approval gain and a 2 bps cost saving can be compared at all.

Two honest caveats. The LTV term is not measurable at decision time and probably never will be; it should be a configured constant per segment, declared as such, not a model output pretending to precision. And an economic objective that is wrong is more dangerous than an approval objective that is wrong, because it can rationalise declining a good transaction. The objective must be a governed artefact with the same change control as a strategy, and the same holdout discipline. [J]

3. Payment intelligence as a service

The review's worked example — authorisation dropped, here is the issuer, the BIN range, the acquirer, the policy change, the time, the revenue impact and the recommended action with a confidence level — is the cheapest high-value item in the entire document. Nearly all of it is a presentation of data the FY2027 evidence build already produces.

WHAT IT NEEDS	WHERE IT ALREADY EXISTS
Decision records with context	Decision platform evidence store, PV-2027
Outcome joins at several horizons	Already specified for the holdout
Attribution of a change to a cause	Partly — requires change-event correlation, which is new work
Recommended action with an expected effect	Requires the economic objective above
A merchant-facing surface	New. The only substantial build in the list.

It should be a named FY2027 deliverable rather than an FY2029 aspiration, because it is the first thing a merchant can see from the evidence infrastructure. Everything else we are building in FY2027 is invisible until it produces an optimization result; this is visible from the first month of data.

4. The four horizons

Open, intelligent, economic, autonomous. Adopted as the time axis of the strategy, with entry gates added — see Part IV. The naming is good, it is memorable, and it survives being repeated by people who have not read the document, which is the only real test of a strategic frame.

5. Expanding the instrument graph to transaction and network intelligence

PV-2027 already has an instrument-intelligence graph. The review is right that the layers above it — behaviour by transaction context, and performance by acquirer, processor and network — are the same asset extended, and that separating them was arbitrary. Adopted as a layering, with a caveat on naming in the next section.

6. The agentic extension to the payment model

Adopted, and pulled forward. This is developed in Part IV because the timing argument is the substance of it.

What we adopt with a stated condition

> Three recommendations are right in substance and would cause damage if adopted without the condition attached. The condition is the whole value of this section.

RECOMMENDATION	ADOPTED	THE CONDITION
Rename Payment Instrument Intelligence to Payment Intelligence Platform	The four-layer model: instrument, transaction, network, feeding economic intelligence and the decision engine.	**Not the boundary rename, not this year.** Product boundaries in EA-001 are named, funded and being staffed against. Renaming a boundary mid-cycle costs a re-plan across the control plane, the entitlement catalogue and every product charter that references it, and buys a better word. Adopt the layers now; rename at the next architecture cycle, if the layers have made the old name genuinely wrong.
Economic Value per Orchestrated Dollar as the north star	As the metric the strategy is ultimately judged on.	**Do not report it until nine of its twelve terms are attributable.** Three are not measurable today. Publishing a north star that is a quarter assumption is how a strategy loses its audience in year two. Detail in the final section of this part.
Rail-neutral money movement architecture	Every payout capability built so that a new rail is a configuration rather than a rewrite.	**The architecture, not the rail.** Leaving the slot open costs an abstraction we should have anyway. Filling it with a stablecoin rail is a regulatory programme with a different approval path, and it should have an explicit exercise condition rather than a date. Condition stated in Part IV.

What we adapt

> Five recommendations are directionally right and wrong in a way that matters. In each case the review has collapsed a distinction that exists for a reason.

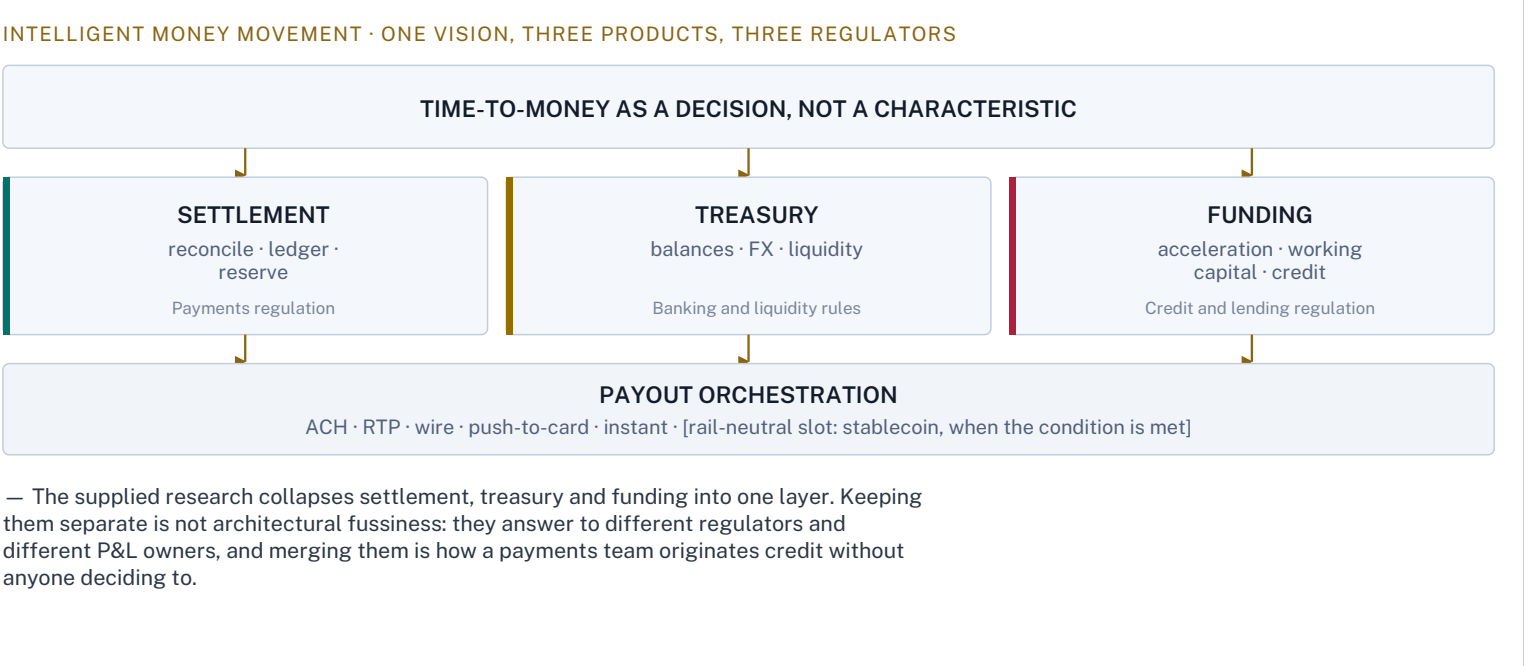
1. Multi-acquiring — reposition, do not demote

The review says multi-acquiring can no longer be the primary differentiation. Correct. It then reads as though it should therefore matter less. It should matter more, for a reason the review states in one line and then drops: multi-acquiring is the data acquisition mechanism, and after the exploration arithmetic in Part II it is the *only* mechanism by which the intelligence moat becomes real.

The adaptation: move it from the top of the external narrative to the top of the internal investment case. Externally it becomes the thing we do; internally it becomes the thing everything else waits on. Those are not in tension, and confusing them is how a pillar loses its funding right after it loses its slogan.

2. Intelligent money movement — keep the three products separate

The framing is adopted: time-to-money as a decision the platform makes rather than a characteristic the merchant inherits. That is a genuine improvement on "accelerated funds".



— The supplied research collapses settlement, treasury and funding into one layer. Keeping them separate is not architectural fussiness: they answer to different regulators and different P&L owners, and merging them is how a payments team originates credit without anyone deciding to.

What is not adopted is collapsing settlement, treasury and funding into one layer. They answer to different regulators, carry different risk, and have different P&L owners. PV-2027 separates them deliberately, and the reason is not architectural fussiness: merging them is the mechanism by which a payments team ends up originating credit without anyone having decided that it should. One vision, one payout orchestration layer, three products with three owners.

3. The foundation model — adopt the architecture, not the date

The target shape is right: transaction, to a learned representation, to prediction services, to the decision platform. The decision platform already has the slot — a model is another registered strategy class with a propensity and a holdout, which is a genuine head start and worth saying out loud.

FY2028 is wrong as a delivery date, for two reasons that have nothing to do with modelling capability:

CONSTRAINT	WHY IT BINDS
We have not collected the data	The evidence store starts filling in FY2027. A representation learned on a year of single-path data with thin counterfactual coverage would be an expensive way to reproduce what a rules engine already does. The input constrains the output and no amount of funding compresses it.
Model risk governance	A model that influences authorisation, decline and funding decisions in a bank is a governed model under SR 11-7: documented development, independent validation, ongoing monitoring, and a defensible account of why it decided what it decided. That is a real programme and it is the binding constraint, not the machine learning. It also argues for a specific architecture — predictions that feed a governed decision layer, rather than a model that decides — which is the shape PV-2027 already has.

The adaptation: FY2028 builds the representation and the first prediction services under model governance, evaluated offline and shadowed in production. Models influence live decisions when the validation and the evidence volume both say so, which is likely to be FY2029. Naming the gate is more useful than naming the year.

4. Local payment methods — coverage, not count

Matching a published method count is a losing and pointless race. The right target is coverage of the markets our four buyer segments actually sell in, and the portability principle means most of that coverage is reachable through acquirers rather than built. Answer the question procurement is really asking, which is whether the merchant can sell where they sell.

5. Network-scale fraud — the same pooled-portfolio problem

The review treats fraud network scale as a separate gap. It is the same gap as cross-acquirer instrument behaviour, with the same answer: the signal is portfolio-level, the consent and entitlement questions are identical, and the governance should be built once and used by both. Treating them as two programmes would duplicate the hardest part, which is the data-rights model rather than the modelling.

What we decline

> Four recommendations are declined. Two on substance, two on sequence. In each case the trigger that would reopen the decision is stated, because a refusal without a trigger is just a deferral nobody scheduled.

DECLINED	THE ARGUMENT FOR IT	WHY WE DECLINE	WHAT WOULD REOPEN IT
Retire the FY2027 positioning now	"The acquirer that does not need to be your only acquirer" has been matched, so it will not survive as three-year external positioning.	It is an FY2027 internal thesis for a year we have not executed. Retiring the framing before the capability ships leaves the organisation with an ambition and no sentence, at exactly the moment it needs a sentence to fund against. The replacement is also a promise about intelligence we cannot yet keep. Sequence it, do not swap it.	It retires when multi-acquiring is generally available and the first optimization result is published with an interval. Expected FY2028.
Replace five pillars with four layers	The layers are a cleaner articulation and map to the horizons.	The pillars are how the organisation is currently funded, staffed and held accountable. Re-cutting the strategy document does not re-cut the org chart; it produces a document that no longer matches how work is assigned. Pillars are the ownership axis, horizons are the time axis. Keep both, on different axes.	A planning cycle in which ownership is genuinely re-cut. Not a document revision.
Merchant of record	Adjacent, monetisable, and a competitor is doing it.	Becoming seller of record changes tax collection, consumer protection and regulatory posture in ways that require a legal-entity answer before a product answer. For a bank that is a different order of question from a product decision, and nobody has done the entity work.	A legal-entity structure and a tax opinion. Until then it is not a roadmap item, it is a corporate project.
Commerce runtime and storefront	It appears in their strategy, so it looks like a category we are missing.	Different buyer, no adjacency to anything we own, and no credible path to competence. Entering it would signal that the strategy has no edges, which is more damaging than the gap.	Nothing foreseeable. This one is a genuine no.

ON DECLINING THINGS A COMPETITOR IS DOING

The hardest discipline in a competitive review is refusing to treat a competitor's roadmap as our requirements document. A well-run company builds things that suit its own position; copying the list without copying the position produces a portfolio that is second-best at everything.

Two of the four declines above are of the strongest-sounding recommendations in the review. That is roughly the expected ratio, and if it were zero this document would not be worth the time it took.

The positioning question

> The review proposes replacing our positioning line today. The right answer is that we need two lines, and the second one has an entry condition.

HORIZON	THE LINE	WHY IT IS THE RIGHT ONE FOR THAT MOMENT
Now to FY2028	The acquirer that does not need to be your only acquirer.	It is a claim about posture, not capability, so it is true before the capability ships. It is the sentence that gets multi-acquiring funded internally and gets us into the orchestration conversation externally. It is matched by a competitor, which weakens it as differentiation but not as an entry point.
FY2028 onward	The platform that optimises the economics of every payment, and every dollar that follows it.	A claim about capability, which means it is a lie until the capability exists. It becomes true when orchestrated volume produces cross-acquirer evidence and the first result is published with an interval. Said before then, it is the kind of claim a procurement team tests and we fail.

THE SUPPORTING STRUCTURE, USABLE NOW

Under either line, the three-part support the review proposes is good and does not depend on which headline is in force:

> One payment abstraction across every acquirer. One intelligence layer across every transaction. One economic control plane across payment, settlement and funding.

The first clause is true today. The second and third are directional and should be spoken as direction — which enterprise buyers accept, provided the distinction between what ships and what is coming is drawn by us rather than discovered by them.

One further point the review does not make. Our positioning has to work against two different competitors with opposite objections. Against an independent orchestrator, the objection is that we are conflicted, and the answer is measured neutrality and published holdouts. Against Stripe, the objection is that they know more and move faster, and the answer is cost of funds, estate presence and cross-acquirer breadth. A single sentence that tries to answer both will answer neither well, so the segment-level messaging in PV-2027 should carry the split explicitly. [J]

Economic value per orchestrated dollar

> Adopted as the north star, and not reported until it can be defended. Those are not in conflict; the gap between them is the FY2027 build.

The metric answers the question our whole strategy raises and the old metrics cannot: not “did we acquire the transaction” but “how much economic value did we create from controlling it”. It is the right question and it reframes the multi-acquiring economics correctly.

ECONOMIC VALUE PER ORCHESTRATED DOLLAR · AND WHICH TERMS WE CAN ACTUALLY MEASURE

WHAT IT ADDS

+ Orchestration revenue metered today	**+ Acquiring margin** metered today	**+ Instrument revenue** metered today
+ Treasury revenue metered today	**+ Funding revenue** metered today	+ Optimization value needs a holdout

WHAT IT SUBTRACTS

− Infrastructure cost allocated today	**− Connector cost** allocated today	**− Funding cost** known today
− Fraud loss measured today	− Incentive cost needs attribution	− Migration cost needs attribution

NINE OF TWELVE TERMS ARE MEASURABLE TODAY. THREE ARE NOT.

The three that are not are the three the metric exists to capture. Publishing it early means publishing a number we cannot defend.

— Adopt the metric; do not report it until the evidence infrastructure closes the last three terms. A north star that is a quarter assumption is how a strategy loses its audience in year two.

The three terms that are not yet measurable

TERM	WHY IT IS HARD	WHAT CLOSES IT
Optimization value	It is by definition a counterfactual: what we earned above what would have happened anyway. There is no accounting entry for it.	The permanent holdout, plus propensity and fallback logging at decision time. Cannot be reconstructed afterwards, which is why PV-2027 puts evidence logging first.
Incentive cost	Pricing concessions made to win orchestrated volume are negotiated per deal and recorded in a contract, not against a transaction.	Metering that ties a commercial concession to the volume it bought. New work, and organisationally awkward, because it makes the cost of a discount visible against the value it produced.
Migration cost	Spread across engineering, operations and merchant effort, and capitalised inconsistently.	A migration cost model attached to the six-stage model in PV-2027, carried per merchant rather than as a programme overhead.

WHY THIS MATTERS MORE THAN IT SOUNDS

The three unmeasurable terms are precisely the three the metric exists to capture. The nine measurable ones are the ones a conventional P&L already reports. A version published today would therefore be a conventional margin calculation wearing a new name — which is worse than not publishing it, because it would be defended, then questioned, then quietly abandoned, taking the idea with it.

Adopt it as the destination. Put the three terms on the FY2027 dependency map as prerequisites. Report the metric when they close, and until then report the nine terms honestly as what they are.

There is a second-order benefit worth naming. Because optimization value can only be closed by the holdout, adopting this metric makes the holdout load-bearing for the company’s headline number rather than for a product team’s scorecard. That is the strongest available defence against the holdout being negotiated away, which PV-2027 identifies as the single most likely way the evidence strategy fails. [J]

PART

IV — The trajectory

19 The selection rule

20 Four horizons, and their gates

21 Agentic commerce, pulled forward

22 The stablecoin option

23 What lateness actually costs

24 What changes in PV-2027

25 The decisions this document asks for

The selection rule

> One rule decides most of the disagreements between this document and the review it responds to. It is worth stating on its own, because it will keep being useful after the specifics here have gone stale.

We compete against an organisation that ships faster than we do and will continue to, for structural reasons: a self-serve base learns in days, a regulated enterprise estate learns in quarters. That ratio is not a performance problem to be managed away. It is a property of the customers we have chosen. [J]

THE SELECTION RULE · WHICH ADVANTAGES SURVIVE A FASTER COMPETITOR

COMPOUNDS WITH TIME IN MARKET — BUILD THESE FIRST

Bank funding · installed estate · evidence store · instrument behaviour · migration muscle

Their value rises every month whether or not we ship anything new. A competitor cannot catch up by shipping faster.

DEPENDS ON SHIPPING SPEED — DO NOT COMPETE HERE

Developer surface · API ergonomics · method count · dashboard breadth · feature parity

Their value resets every release. We lose this race structurally — enterprise change control is measured in quarters.

CHEAP NOW, RUINOUS LATER — DO THESE EVEN IF UNUSED

Contract schema · principal and mandate objects · evidence logging · rail-neutral payout slot

A schema version today; a breaking change across every signed integration in three years.

EXPENSIVE NOW, CHEAP LATER — DEFER WITHOUT GUILT

Foundation model · agent wallets · stablecoin issuance · commerce runtime

Each depends on inputs we do not have yet. Starting early buys nothing except a sunk cost.

PREFER THE LEFT COLUMN. FUND THE BOTTOM LEFT EVEN WHEN NOTHING USES IT YET.

— This is the single rule that decides most of the disagreements in this document. It is also why the recommendation to build a foundation model in FY2028 and agent identity in FY2030 is exactly the wrong way round.

Two axes. The first asks whether an advantage *compounds with time in market* or *resets with each release*. The second asks whether the cost of doing something rises or falls the longer we wait.

QUADRANT	RULE	EXAMPLES
Compounds with time	Fund first, fund through downturns, and measure in years.	Cost of funds; installed estate; evidence history; instrument behaviour; migration capability; merchant trust from published results.
Resets each release	Build to sufficiency. Never enter as a race. Stop measuring ourselves on it.	Developer surface; API ergonomics; payment method count; dashboard breadth; feature parity.
Cheap now, ruinous later	Do it now even with no consumer, because the cost curve is the argument, not the demand.	Contract schema; principal, agent and mandate objects; evidence logging; rail-neutral payout slot; bitemporality; key epochs.
Expensive now, cheaper later	Defer without apology. State the gate. Revisit on the gate, not on a competitor announcement.	Foundation model; agent wallets; stablecoin issuance; commerce runtime; merchant of record.

THE RULE APPLIED TO THE REVIEW'S TWO BIGGEST RECOMMENDATIONS

The review puts a payments foundation model in FY2028 and agent identity in FY2030.

A foundation model is *expensive now, cheaper later*: it waits on evidence volume and model governance, and starting early buys a sunk cost rather than a head start. Agent identity is *cheap now, ruinous later*: three objects above the payment intent, nullable, costing a schema version today and a breaking change across every signed integration in three years.

The rule says swap them. That single inversion is the most consequential recommendation in this document, and it costs almost nothing to act on.

Four horizons, and their gates

> The horizon names are adopted from the review. The gates are not in it, and they are the part that makes the horizons usable for planning rather than for slides.

A horizon without an entry condition is a wish with a date attached. Each gate below is something that can be observed to be false, which is the only property that makes a gate worth having.



HORIZON	WHAT IS TRUE AT THE END	THE GATE INTO THE NEXT
FY2027 — OPEN	Multi-acquiring generally available; portability measured across the fifteen surfaces; control plane live; migration under way on named merchants; evidence logged on eligible traffic.	Evidence logging live on a majority of eligible traffic, with propensity and fallback recorded at decision time, and a holdout with a governance owner who is not the commercial owner. ***If this gate is not met, FY2028 produces models trained on data that cannot support them.***
FY2028 — INTELLIGENT	Instrument and transaction graph populated; pooled exploration running; first cross-acquirer segment results at coarse granularity; prediction services in shadow.	Enough pooled orchestrated volume to resolve at least channel × issuer group at 100 bps within a quarter, plus model-risk validation completed for the first prediction service. ***Both, not either.***
FY2029 — ECONOMIC	Economic objective live in production strategies; money movement products metered and priced; funding decisions informed by evidence; the north-star metric reportable.	Every term of the objective attributable to a decision, including the three that are not measurable today. ***Without that, the economic control plane optimises a number nobody can audit.***
FY2030 — AUTONOMOUS	Agent-initiated volume supported natively; mandates enforced as policy; settlement rails selected by economics rather than configuration.	Not applicable — but the entry condition was paid in FY2027, when the contract objects went in.

THE GATES ARE ALSO A DEFENCE

Written gates have a second function beyond planning. When a competitor announces something in the FY2029 column and somebody asks why we are not doing it yet, the answer is a gate that has not opened rather than a judgement that can be argued with in a meeting.

This matters most for the foundation model, which will be raised repeatedly and each time with more urgency. The answer should be the same each time: the evidence volume and the validation, not the calendar.

Agentic commerce, pulled forward

> The review puts this in FY2030. The expensive part belongs there. The cheap part belongs in the next schema version, and the reason has nothing to do with how promising agentic commerce is.



— We do not need agent wallets, agent-to-agent settlement or a machine payments protocol in FY2027. We need the four boxes, nullable, in the contract — so that when the rest arrives it is a feature rather than a migration.

Three new objects and one renamed step, and all four sit ***above*** the payment intent. Everything above the payment intent is in the integration contract, which means it is in every merchant integration, every certification, and every partner SDK.

WHEN WE ADD IT	WHAT IT COSTS
FY2027	A schema version. Four nullable objects on an API with a modest number of live integrations, most of which are ours or under active migration. Cost measured in weeks.
FY2030	A breaking change to the contract, across every enterprise integration signed in the intervening three years, each requiring change control, recertification and a merchant-side release. Cost measured in a programme.

What we actually build in FY2027

OBJECT	WHAT IT HOLDS	WHY IT CANNOT WAIT
Principal	The party on whose behalf the payment is made: human, business, platform or system. Distinct from the party submitting it.	Once an integration assumes submitter equals principal, separating them later is a semantic change to every downstream record, including the ones in the ledger.
Agent identity	The identity of the software acting for the principal, if any. Null for a human checkout.	It has to reach the risk and authentication layers as a first-class attribute. Retrofitting an identity into a decision context after models are trained on its absence is worse than adding it empty.
Mandate	The permission: limits on amount, merchant, category, geography, time, and the revocation path.	This is a policy object and we already have a policy platform. It is close to free now and it is the thing regulators will ask about first when agent-initiated volume becomes material.
Decision	The explicit decision record between intent and attempt.	Already implied by the decision platform. Making it a named object in the contract is what lets a merchant or an auditor ask why a payment went the way it did.

WHAT WE ARE NOT BUILDING

No agent wallets. No agent-to-agent settlement. No implementation of a specific machine payments protocol. Those are genuinely FY2029 or later, the protocols are unsettled, and implementing an unsettled protocol early buys a migration rather than a position.

The asymmetry is the entire argument: the contract objects are cheap now and ruinous later; the protocol implementations are expensive now and cheap later. Same technology, opposite timing, and the rule in the first section of this part tells us which is which without further debate.

The stablecoin option

> The correct answer is neither “we must become a stablecoin company” nor “not our problem”. It is an option, and an option has a price and an exercise condition.

WHAT WE DO NOW	COST	WHAT IT BUYS
Rail-neutral payout architecture: a settlement instruction is a rail-agnostic object, and a rail is a registered capability with its own timing, cost and reconciliation behaviour.	An abstraction we should have anyway for RTP, push-to-card and instant.	Adding a stablecoin rail becomes a connector and a compliance review rather than a re-architecture.
Treat digital-asset settlement as a rail in the capability catalogue, entitled but not activated.	A catalogue entry and a policy rule.	The control plane can answer “can this merchant settle in this asset” with a policy decision rather than a code change.
Nothing else.	—	A decision we have not yet had to make, which is what an option is for.

THE EXERCISE CONDITION

We build the rail when **two** of the following three are true, and not before:

1. A named enterprise merchant or platform in our pipeline makes stablecoin settlement a stated requirement, not a curiosity, in a deal we would otherwise win
2. The regulatory path for our institution to hold or move the asset on a merchant’s behalf is settled enough for our own risk function to sign a standard control framework
3. Cross-border payout economics through the rail beat our existing correspondent route by a margin large enough to survive the compliance overhead

Written down, this stops the question being reopened by each competitor announcement, and it makes “not yet” a position rather than an absence of one.

The general principle is worth extracting, because it applies to more than stablecoins: **our funding advantage and our regulatory slowness are the same fact.** The balance sheet that makes accelerated funds a gate-2 pass is the reason issuance, merchant-of-record and agent custody run through approval paths a fintech does not have. We can claim the advantage or complain about the constraint. Claiming both, in the same document, is the tell of a strategy that has not decided what it is. [J]

What lateness actually costs

> The case for urgency should be made with a mechanism, not with adjectives. Here are the three mechanisms by which being late becomes irreversible, and the one by which it does not.

MECHANISM	HOW IT LOCKS IN	WINDOW [J]
Evidence cannot be backfilled	Propensity and fallback exist only if recorded at decision time. A year without logging is a year that can never be analysed, and it delays every downstream horizon by exactly that year.	Continuous. Every month of delay is a month of permanent loss, which is the strongest argument in the FY2027 plan and the least intuitive.
Orchestration becomes a procurement line	While orchestration is a project, our presence inside the estate is decisive. Once it is a standard procurement category with an established shortlist, it is a feature comparison and we lose on features.	Perhaps two to three years, and shortening. This is the clock on our migration advantage.
Data compounds against us	A competitor accumulating cross-processor observations from orchestrated volume begins to build the breadth asset we assumed was uniquely ours. Their depth plus our kind of breadth would close the one gap where scale does not decide.	Slow but one-directional. Depends entirely on how much third-party volume their orchestration actually attracts, which is the single most important thing on the verification list.
Cost of funds does not erode	The counter-example, and worth stating. No amount of competitor execution changes our cost of funds or their lack of a charter. This advantage is not on a clock.	Indefinite — which is why the packaging gap on funds is a self-inflicted delay rather than a competitive one, and the easiest thing on this list to fix.

THE HONEST SUMMARY OF URGENCY

One thing on our plan is genuinely irreversible if delayed, and it is the least glamorous: evidence logging. Two things are on a multi-year clock. One thing is on no clock at all and is the one we are slowest to package.

A plan that reflected that ordering would put evidence logging and funds packaging ahead of anything in the intelligence horizon. PV-2027 broadly does. This review should not be allowed to reorder it in favour of the items that make the better slide.

What changes in PV-2027

> The purpose of a document like this is an edit list, not a point of view.
> Fourteen changes, in the order they appear in PV-2027.

PV-2027 SECTION	CHANGE	SIZE
01 The thesis	Add the commoditisation test result and the two-line positioning sequence. The five pillars stay; their billing changes.	Moderate
03 Why now	Add the validation argument: a competitor opening its core is evidence for the thesis, and the market risk has fallen while execution risk has risen.	Small
04 Multi-acquiring	Reframe from primary differentiation to data-acquisition mechanism and critical path. Reference the exploration arithmetic.	Moderate
05 The API model	Rename to portable payment infrastructure; enumerate the fifteen surfaces; add the per-surface portability measure.	Moderate
06 Accelerated funds	Adopt the time-to-money framing and the payout orchestration layer; keep the three products separate; add the packaging gap as an explicit finding.	Moderate
07–08 Instrument intelligence	Add the transaction and network layers; add the exploration programme, the granularity ladder and the pooled-portfolio consequence. Keep the boundary name.	Large
09 Payment optimization	Move the objective from approval or cost to expected economic value; add the four approvals that contractual proof requires.	Large
11 Economics	Add the contestable-cost-stack analysis and the revenue-side argument for an expected value objective.	Moderate
12 Buyer segments	Split the messaging by competitor type: measured neutrality against independents, funding and estate against Stripe.	Moderate
20 The AI layer	Restate the foundation model as FY2028 build under governance and FY2029 in live decisions; name both gates.	Moderate
21 The payment sequence	Add principal, agent identity, mandate and the explicit decision record as nullable contract objects.	Large
28 Metrics	Add economic value per orchestrated dollar as the destination metric with its three open terms listed as prerequisites, not as a reported number.	Moderate
34–36 Waves and migration	Overlay the four horizons as a time axis over the existing pillar ownership; add the entry gates.	Moderate
New section	Payment intelligence as a service — the merchant-facing surface over the evidence store, as an FY2027 deliverable.	New

Nothing on this list requires re-cutting the product boundaries in EA-001 or the platform architecture in EA-002, which is the useful conclusion: the architecture survived the comparison intact. What changed is the objective function, the contract schema, one new merchant-facing surface, and the order in which we say things.

The decisions this document asks for

> Seven decisions. Four are cheap and should be taken in the room. Three are not, and are named so they do not get taken by default.

#	DECISION	OWNER	COST OF DECIDING WRONG
1	**Adopt the two-line positioning sequence** rather than retiring the FY2027 line now.	Product leadership	Low. Reversible at any planning cycle.
2	**Adopt the economic objective function** for routing and decision strategies, with the LTV term declared as a configured constant.	Product leadership	Low to take, high to get wrong later. Requires the governance treatment in decision 5.
3	**Add the four agentic contract objects to the FY2027 schema**, nullable and unused.	Product and architecture	Very low now. A programme in three years.
4	**Fund payment intelligence as a service as an FY2027 deliverable**, not FY2029.	Product leadership	Low. Mostly a surface over data we are already collecting.
5	**Approve contractual economic proof** — performance-linked revenue variance, a publishable interval that may be negative, a holdout with a non-commercial owner, and comparisons that may show our own acquiring losing.	Commercial, Legal, Finance, Acquiring	High either way. Approving it is the moat; declining it quietly is how the moat becomes a marketing line. This should be a decision, not a drift.
6	**Establish a pooled, centrally governed exploration budget** with the same immutability as the holdout, and the merchant consent and entitlement model that pooling requires.	Product, Legal, Data governance	High. Without pooling there is no cross-acquirer intelligence at any useful granularity, and the arithmetic in Part II is the evidence.
7	**Accept the stablecoin exercise condition** in place of a stablecoin programme.	Product and Risk leadership	Low. It converts a recurring debate into a stated trigger.

WHAT HAPPENS IF NOTHING IS DECIDED

Decisions 1 to 4 are cheap enough that inaction is a reasonable outcome; they will be taken eventually and the cost of delay is small, with the exception of number 3, which gets more expensive every quarter.

Decisions 5 and 6 are different. Both will be decided by default if they are not decided explicitly, and the default in both cases is no: the holdout gets softened under commercial pressure, and the exploration budget gets negotiated to zero by the first merchant who asks a reasonable question about it. Both defaults remove the only capability that survives the commoditisation test with a clean pass on proof.

That is the sharpest way to put the conclusion of this whole comparison. Stripe has taken two of our five pillars. The two most valuable things we have left are an advantage we have not packaged and a discipline we have not yet agreed to accept. Neither is at risk from a competitor.